NEWS ON AIR: SPOTLIGHT

Women-Centric Development: From Welfare to Empowerment

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Meghana Bose (Anchor): This is Akashwani in the program spotlight. Now we bring you a discussion on women's centric development from welfare to empowerment. The participants are Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan, professor at Delhi University and Magna Bose, anchor. The Ministry of Women and Child Development hosted a two-day departmental summit in New Delhi on October 8th and 9th focusing on women's empowerment and child development. The summit brought together representatives from the center and states to discuss key priorities including nutrition, early childhood education, child protection, women's safety and the effective implementation of empowerment schemes. The broader objective was to advance the vision of a supit surakit and sashak bharat as foundation for vikasid bharat 2047. To discuss this we are joined by Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan, professor at Delhi University. Welcome to the program.

Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan: Thank you so much for having me in the program.

Meghana Bose: Women-centric development is increasingly being discussed in terms of empowerment rather than welfare alone. What does this shift mean?

Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan: We need to understand what does welfare and empowerment mean? Welfare generally includes subsidies that you're taking care the basics are taken care of. What do I say by basics? That means that your food is taken care of, your shelter is taken care of. So when your basics are taken care of, that is what is meant by welfare. But when we talk about empowerment, you know, in empowerment, women are not seen generally not seen merely as beneficiaries, but they're also becoming agents of change. Now if you see the focus of the government is not just to see women as beneficiaries that they're taking some of the other benefits of the government schemes or subsidies but they're contributing in this charter of nation making becoming a very active agent of change in this idea of vix bharat and contributing equally. Empowerment is more about expanding horizons expanding their spectrum understanding what all the things enhancing their capability.

This government focuses on capability enhancement approach rather than just giving them freebies. They're becoming more and more owners of things. They're owners of enterprises. They're owners of cultural entrepreneurship. They're becoming owners of lot of things. And empowerment if you want to understand empowerment is something which covers lot of pillars. First political pillar. You see maximum most of the Indian women politically active. When I say politically active, that doesn't mean that you just have to be part of the political corridors of the nation. But everybody votes, everybody votes for the change and every vote that they do matters. So they are very actively involved in the politics of the country. When I talk about socially, socially you see women are becoming part of STEM, women are there in education, women are there in performances, you see women everywhere. Now women have become a part of the society in a way that you see them around. Now women are not just within the four walls of their household but they're seen in public spaces. They're seen with interacting with the public infrastructure. They seen interacting with the public system distribute with everything.

Third is cultural empowerment which also we see in India we have had amazing self-help group like legit papar where a harbor has done their study that how a self-help group a conglomeration of women who came together and by selling papa they've made a complete enterprise of it and even today if you see if you go into the hintterlands of different states you see women self-help groups are so proactively working which ensures economic empowerment also with them and with all these different forms of empowerment the most important thing which comes is that of dignity that you're ensuring women are dignified.

Meghana Bose: Absolutely. The departmental summit was based on the idea of cooperative federalism bringing the center and the states together to discuss priorities, implementation challenges and time bound action. The government has also introduced several initiatives including the pradhan mantri matraandhana yojana mission shaki mission vatsalya portion 2.0 to and Batty Bacho Batty Bhau focusing on women's welfare, maternal health, nutrition, child protection and empowerment. How can these schemes be better integrated to ensure that women and children receive comprehensive support and that India moves from welfare based interventions towards inclusive and sustainable development for all.

Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan: If you see all the schemes that you have mentioned, they are addressing one particular pillar of the **empowerment** that I have mentioned. For instance, if you see batty bachi praha because of this particular scheme, the gross enrollment ratio of the women of the young girls, the adolescent girls, it we saw a rise of girls. Now, if you **substantiated** with sukanya samidi, which is another scheme which is run by the government where the government is giving you some sort of interest when a girl child is born. So first you're giving incentive to parents to have girl child. Second, you're providing them with second with Anganwari workers and Asha workers. You're giving them the early childhood care and you have brilliant schemes of the government which actually addresses the early childhood maternal health care also schemes like nervana portion bhai b and all these schemes that is the second third stages bacha beta and then you have another schemes of which also addresses about the **vulnerabilities** like we have anemia mission which is addressing because 58% approx 58% of the women in our country is suffering of this because of there's a little lack in the schemes and the **implementation** of the schemes and that lack could be because of the somewhere lack of cooperation maybe between the center of the state or the state is not able to utilize the funds properly but there is definitely a lack that we're not able to address.

But the schemes which are coming in the government they're addressing every stage of the girl from early childhood care adolescent until she attains something you have the schemes like mudra yoja you have schemes like standup India which promote women entrepreneurs also so through schemes you're taking care of the woman from the day they are born till the time they become economic empowered and you have brilliant schemes like Navia which is nurturing **aspirations** through **vocational** training for young adults and girls where also again you're focusing on the **empowerment** of the girls you're focusing how women can become there's a shift how we see women now we do not see women merely as just being a part of something but they are the people who are defining that part of the government.

Meghana Bose: Right one of the four key themes of the summit as we all know uh Dr. Paswan is the reimagining of Angenwari centers for better nutrition and early education. Angenwari centers are often the first point of contact between government services and young children, pregnant women and mothers. What should a modern Angari center provide beyond just supplementary nutrition?

Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan: You know it's a very good question and there we need to have a very deep study on this and research should come out. But from a very brief idea that I I did a research with I interviewed Asha workers. Asha workers right now you know they are next door help when a person is pregnant and they are the first interaction that a person has with is with Asha workers when a person is pregnant in our country but you know they are just restricted to the aspect of health and they're only restricted till the time the child is born and once the child is born then only for few days maybe for thousand days or maybe for few days the child's nutrition they're taking care of but we need an **intervention** in that part because maternal health is somewhere missing when a child is born a mother also has some physical **deficiencies** some nutritional **deficiencies** which also needs to be addressed which somehow we have failed to address. So there need we need to have an **intervention** in that part of also. Second in the training of the asha work we need to have an approach for more responsive caregiving.

When I say about more responsive caregiving, it should be about that the Asha workers also should be trained that how a child of 3 month, how a child of 6 month, how a child of an infant of 9 month are being treated because a need of a 3mon baby is very different from a 9month baby. So a responsive caregiving plan needs to be made and mandated so that every child is completely taken care in our country. Thirdly, I feel there should be a safe infrastructure made a stray institutions made where a person can come and if there's some some sort of problem, health issues, mental issue, we do have institutions but we need to more incentivize those institutions and we need to provide we need to make them more workable so that we have that that access to that institution should be better. Thirdly, I also feel that you know we need to focus a little more on early childhood caregiving because early childhood caregiving is just not restricted to the health factor of the child but it is also about developing his or her **cognitive** understanding also. Most of the brain development of the child happens in the early years mostly in 2 years or 3 years. So that **cognitive** understanding development part of the child is missing. Those are the few things which I think that we need to equip our Asha workers in Anganwari centers more efficiently.

Meghana Bose: The second major theme of the summit is also strengthening the protection system for vulnerable children. What according to you are the most important gaps in India's child protection system today?

Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan: Uh you know in child protection system now first we need to define that what referring to vulnerable sections of the society. Vulnerable section of children would be people coming from **marginalized** section that can be one area. Second people as to young children who are living on the bordering areas they are at the cost of **trafficking** they are the on the verge of **trafficking**. So it needs a very **multi-pronged** approach we need to have for this. But the most important thing which I felt that you know we have over we are very dependent on this institutional support for these things. Institutional support is important. I agree. State is there, center is there, then you have child welfare committees, you have juvenile justice committees there. You have child care institutions. There are lot of institutions that are made. But only these institutions are not going to make a greater impact. For that greater impact, in order to prevent these things happening, we need to strengthen our family system. Our approach is very reactive. When I say reactive, we always act after something has happened. But rather than having a very reactive approach towards these things to we should more focus that we should prevent such things from happening. We should prevent the crime. How do we prevent the crime? Of course, first is creating **conducive** environment. Police protection should be there. But the first foundational interaction child has with outside world is with the family. So we need to strengthen the family system and make sure that the child feels safe within the family system. And then the other layers of foundational interaction comes in the life of the child.

Meghana Bose: Right. Women's safety is also the third central theme of the summit. Mom, how can women be made more aware of helplines, legal assistance, counseling, shelter and other support services provided by the government?

Dr. Aditi Narayani Paswan: We need to do a door-to-door campaign and we need to get deeper into the rural segment of the society. You know we have NCW national commission for women. We have state commissions. We have legal assistance but mostly women are unaware of this. Right? First barrier they face is the access to these places. How do we get access? You know NCW runs a helpline which might be giving you that how to cope with domestic violence. But if I'm a victim of domestic violence, how to get access to that thing is the main problem. So we need to ensure the accessibility. Now how do we ensure the accessibility? We ensure the accessibility by making sure that every woman firstly is aware of the rights that what she's entitled to and what are her rights and secondly if somewhere she feels that she's being violated where to report. Now how do we do so? This can be done I feel is through best is Asha workers because you see Asha workers are the frontline workers during COVID during any time any pandemic that India hits Asha workers are the frontline workers I know we I'm overburdening the Asha workers now but they are the frontline workers they need to be fully equipped or we need to launch another scheme something like Asha workers who are going to work like them and their duty or their work should be that they should go do and talk to women and make them understand that if you feel violated there are schemes of the government, there are government centers where you can come and seek help. So that accessibility would be easier if we have an army of women going around and telling them the things maybe giving them in a handbook maybe taking workshops. So this is the way **dissemination** of information somewhere is lacking when I see women are not able to report and of course second factor as you said is shame. There we have a long history of stigma. We always feel **stigmatized** when we are if something wrong happens to us our we functions like we think okay I might be inappropriately dressed or I might have gone at the wrong time or I might have done something to that's why this is happening but this approach and this psychological thing that has been set in our generationally in our head needs to be changed so we need to enhance our women also to come up and to we need to give them that confidence that you know if something is happening to you you have the right to come and there's a support and ecosystem there standing for you to support you.